WEST VIRGINIA

The Mountain State



The mountains of West Virginia have never made anything easy. The ridges of the Allegheny range fold one into the next like pages of an unfinished book, and the hollows between them—dark, narrow, and fiercely cold in winter—demanded a particular kind of resourcefulness from the people who chose to settle there. It was in those hollows, through the late 1700s and into the 1800s, that buckwheat quietly became something more than a crop. It became a tradition.

German and Scots-Irish immigrants pushed into the Monongahela River valley and the eastern highlands of what was then still Virginia, clearing steep hillsides and working soil that would have discouraged less determined people. They discovered quickly that buckwheat—technically not a grain at all, but the seed of a broadleaf plant—thrived where little else would. It asked almost nothing of the rocky, acidic mountain soil, matured in as few as ten weeks, and could be planted late in the season after other crops had already been harvested. For mountain families scratching out a living between the ridges, it was nothing short of a gift.

Buckwheat flour ground from those mountain harvests found its way into the iron skillets that hung over every hearth from Moorefield to Morgantown. Farmwives mixed the dark, earthy flour with water and a spoonful of sourdough starter the night before, letting the batter ferment slowly in a warm corner of the kitchen while the family slept. By morning, the batter had come alive—bubbling, sour, and deeply fragrant. Poured onto a well-seasoned griddle and cooked over a wood fire, the pancakes rose with a tender crumb and a rich, nutty depth that no ordinary wheat pancake could match. Stacked tall and flooded with sorghum molasses or the dark, robust buckwheat honey produced by the bees that fed on buckwheat blossoms, they were the breakfast that fueled long days of timber work, farming, and the hard physical labor that mountain life required.

The tradition deepened as West Virginia grew. By the late 1800s, Kingwood, the seat of Preston County in the north-central part of the state, had become the self-declared buckwheat capital of the world—and with some justification. Preston County's farmers were producing buckwheat on a scale that supplied mills and markets well beyond the mountains. The county eventually launched its Buckwheat Festival, one of the oldest and most beloved harvest celebrations in Appalachia, where buckwheat pancakes have been served by the thousands every autumn for generations, cooked on long griddles by volunteers who treat the task with the seriousness it deserves.

What makes this dish worth making today is exactly what made it worth making two hundred years ago—it is honest, elemental, and deeply satisfying. The fermented batter gives these pancakes a complexity that surprises people the first time they taste it, something between sourdough bread and a warm autumn morning. Pour on a ribbon of sorghum molasses and you have a breakfast that doesn't just fill you—it roots you to something. To a place, to a people, and to the particular genius of making something extraordinary from whatever the land provides.

Buckwheat pancakes pair beautifully with hearty breakfast meats like country sausage or ham, and a cup of strong black coffee or cider completes the authentic Appalachian experience.

BUCKWHEAT PANCAKES

Every humble buckwheat grain holds the warmth of a thousand mornings worth waking up for.

Yield: 6–8 pancakes

INGREDIENTS

- 1½ tsp active dry yeast
- 3 Tbsp lukewarm water (about 110°F / 43°C)
- 1 cup buttermilk, at room temperature
- ⅔ cup lukewarm water, plus more to thin
- 1⅓ cups buckwheat flour (Preston County–style / light buckwheat if you can find it), plus more as needed
- ⅓ cup all-purpose flour
- ¾ tsp salt
- ⅓ tsp baking soda
- 1½ tsp sugar
- 4 tsp hot water (or 3 Tbsp warm milk)
- 1½ Tbsp unsalted butter, melted (for lacy, crisp edges)
- Bacon grease, lard, or a piece of pork fat, for greasing the griddle
- Softened butter, pure maple syrup, apple butter, and/or sausage gravy, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the Sponge*: The night before (or at least 5 hours ahead), make the sponge. In a large non-reactive bowl or crock (leave plenty of headroom, as it will bubble up and expand), sprinkle the yeast over the 3 Tbsp lukewarm water and let it stand until foamy, about 5 minutes. Whisk in the buttermilk and the ⅔ cup lukewarm water, then stir in the buckwheat flour, all-purpose flour, and salt until you have a smooth, fairly thick batter about the consistency of heavy cream. Add a little more buckwheat flour if it seems thin.
2. *Ferment overnight*: Cover the bowl loosely with a clean kitchen towel or a lid set ajar—do not seal it, since the ferment needs to breathe and release gas. Leave it at room temperature overnight, 12 to 18 hours. The longer and warmer it sits, the more pronounced that classic Buckwheat Belt sourness will be; a cool kitchen and a shorter rest give a milder cake. By morning it should be puffed, bubbly, and smell pleasantly tangy and yeasty.
3. *Doctor the Batter*: When you're ready to bake, dissolve the baking soda and sugar in the hot water and stir this into the risen batter along with the melted butter. This is the traditional step that tames the sour, activates the signature lacy edges, and gives the cakes their lift. The batter will bubble and loosen. Now thin it with lukewarm water, a few tablespoons at a time, until it's genuinely thin and pourable—loose enough to spread on its own into a 7- to 8-inch circle on the griddle without coaxing. Let it rest 10 minutes while the griddle heats.

4. *Heat and Grease the Griddle*: Heat a well-seasoned cast-iron griddle or skillet over medium to medium-high until a drop of water dances and evaporates on contact. Grease it lightly but thoroughly with bacon grease, lard, or a piece of pork fat speared on a fork and rubbed across the surface—the authentic way, and the source of much of the flavor. Re-grease before every cake.
5. *Bake the Cakes*: Pour the batter from a pitcher or large measuring cup with a spout, using about ⅓ to ½ cup per cake, letting it spread into a thin round on its own. Cook undisturbed until the top is covered in small bubbles that pop and stay open, the surface looks dry at the edges, and the underside is deep golden brown and lacy, about 2 minutes. Slide a long thin turner underneath, flip once, and cook the second side until set and browned, about 1 minute more. These are meant to be thin and flexible, not thick and fluffy.
6. *Serve in Stacks*: Serve immediately in stacks of two to four, spreading softened butter between each layer so it melts through, and top with maple syrup, apple butter, or a ladle of sausage gravy. Traditionally these accompany sausage, bacon, and eggs—a full West Virginia breakfast.
7. *Save the Starter*: To keep the tradition going, save at least ½ cup of the un-doctored sponge before you add the baking soda, and refrigerate it in a covered jar for up to a week. To renew for the next batch, feed it with 1 cup lukewarm water, ¼ tsp salt, and enough buckwheat flour to make a stiff batter, then let it ferment overnight again—just as Preston County families have kept their cakes going for generations.



